Epilogue

“I have lived a long life, and I am proud that I spend the whole of my life in the service of my people. I am only proud of this and nothing else. I shall continue to serve until my last breath, and when I die, I can say, that every drop of my blood will invigorate India and strengthen it.”

(Indira Gandhi)

Restructuring India after it won independence from British rule wasn’t easy. The divide between India and Pakistan had separated communities with cultural ties and bound others together of opposing faiths. Many people died in successive, minute reorganizations of the border that was meant to keep Muslims in the north and Hindus in the south. Millions of people crossed the border on foot, carrying their belongings and other family members, hoping to live shoulder to shoulder with families of their own faith. There have been ongoing troubles between neighboring regions.

On the whole, today’s India is a land of peace, opportunity, and diversity. In the Indian Himalayas, where the ways of the ancient Sarasvati met those of the Tibetans, Nepalese, and Chinese, Buddhism and simplicity reigns. It is cold and meager among the peaks where families send their oldest boys to the monasteries to learn the teachings of the Dalai Lama. In addition to the sparse religious communities, the mountains and adjacent plateaus are inhabited by a few lingering nomadic tribes. They subsist largely on barley porridge and yak’s milk, and in the harsh winter months share their own food supply with the livestock.

In the cities, tech companies have sprung up in droves, making IT firms India’s largest private-sector employer. The auto industry, software, and IT make up a significant part of the country’s economy, with agriculture as the largest employer. India’s economy is the fastest growing major economy in the world, thanks to an educated population, diverse resources, and the country’s position within multiple facets of the digital/communications market. Customer service and helplines are one of the country’s biggest exports, and it’s all based on human resources. The ability of most Indians —even decades after the British Raj—to speak and write in English has had an undeniably positive effect on this particular part of India’s modern economy.